MODULE 33 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

What Changed, and What AWS Renamed

The C02 to C03 changes, exam guide v1.1, and everything AWS has moved since the guide was written.

DOMAIN Cross-cutting EXAM WEIGHT All MODULE 33 of 35

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Two kinds of change. The **exam guide** changed, twice. And **AWS** kept changing after the guide was written, which the guide cannot reflect.

The exam is not called what you think

- **SOA-C03 is the AWS Certified CloudOps Engineer - Associate.** AWS renamed the certification with this version.
- The new name applies **only to people who pass SOA-C03**. It is not applied retroactively to existing SysOps Administrator holders.
- Existing holders **need not retake anything**. Their credential remains valid for its full three years.
- Almost every search result, forum post and study guide still calls it SysOps Administrator. Both names describe this exam.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> SOA-C02 ran until 29 September 2025. SOA-C03 began 30 September 2025. Anything written before that date describes a different exam.

Exam mechanics, confirmed

FACT	VALUE
Duration	130 minutes
Questions	65 total: 50 scored, 15 unscored
Question types	Multiple choice and multiple response only
Exam labs	NONE. SOA-C03 has no hands-on lab section
Cost	150 USD
Passing score	720 of 100 to 1000, compensatory scoring
Validity	3 years

ON THE EXAM

A high-ranking third-party site states "$300, 65 questions plus labs, 180 minutes". All three figures are wrong. The labs belonged to C02 and were suspended in March 2023.

The domains changed shape

SOA-C02	SOA-C03
D1 Monitoring, Logging, Remediation, 20%	D1 adds Analysis and Performance Optimization, 22%
D2 Reliability and Business Continuity, 16%	D2 same name, 22%
D3 Deployment, Provisioning, Automation, 18%	D3 same name, 22%
D4 Security and Compliance, 16%	D4 unchanged, 16%
D5 Networking and Content Delivery, 18%	D5 unchanged, 18%
D6 Cost and Performance Optimization, 12%	GONE. Folded into Task 1.3

ON THE EXAM

Domain 6 did not disappear, it moved. Cost and performance questions now arrive inside Domain 1, which is why module 9 and module 10 sat there.

What AWS explicitly added and removed

- **Added:** the CloudWatch agent on **ECS and EKS clusters**, CloudFormation **and AWS CDK**, Region and service selection enforcement, and **CloudWatch network monitoring services**.
- **Moved: VPNs** from the security domain to networking. The old cost and performance tasks into Task 1.3.
- **Removed:** configuring S3 static website hosting.
- **Containers are new scope.** ECR, ECS and EKS were out of scope in C02 and are in scope now. That is the largest single gap in C02-era material.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> The container change matters most. If you are revising from SOA-C02 material, module 21 has no equivalent anywhere in it.

Exam guide v1.1, published 1 June 2026

- **Most courses on the market predate this revision.** AWS publishes revisions about a month before they affect the exam, so 1.1 is live.
- **Services added to the in-scope list:** Amazon Bedrock, **AWS DevOps Agent**, **AWS Health Dashboard**, **Kiro**, and **AWS Security Agent**.
- **Removed from the out-of-scope list**, so no longer explicitly excluded: AppStream 2.0, Augmented AI, AppSync, Cloud Directory, Kendra, and Amazon Q Developer.
- Three of the five additions are **agentic services that went GA in 2026**. That is a deliberate signal about where AWS operations is heading.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Nothing in v1.1 removes content. It adds, which means material written against version 1.0 is incomplete rather than wrong.

The v1.1 skill rewordings that matter

- **1.3.4** added **Amazon S3 Files** to the shared storage list. **4.1.5** added **Config conformance packs**.
- **2.3.4** now names the four DR strategies explicitly: backup and restore, pilot light, warm standby, active/active.
- **1.2.1** dropped User Notifications and auto scaling, and **added Kiro and AWS DevOps Agent**. **3.2.2** added EventBridge and DevOps Agent.
- **1.1.1** now says monitoring for "serverless, compute, **AI**" workloads. **4.2.5** added AWS Security Agent.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Naming the four DR strategies explicitly is the clearest signal in the whole revision. Expect a question that describes a requirement and wants the strategy name.

Still examinable, no longer buildable

FEATURE	CLOSED TO NEW CUSTOMERS
Systems Manager Incident Manager	7 November 2025
Systems Manager Change Manager	7 November 2025
CloudTrail Lake	31 May 2026
ARC readiness check	30 April 2026

ON THE EXAM

Existing customers continue. These remain in the exam guide, so learn what they do, and never propose them for new work.

Removed entirely, not merely closed

FEATURE	GONE
CloudWatch Evidently	End of life 17 October 2025
RDS Performance Insights	End of life 2026. Console redirects to Database Insights
SSM CloudWatch Dashboard	Removed 30 April 2026
SSM Advanced Instances Tier	Removed 30 June 2026. Hybrid nodes now register free
Amazon Inspector Classic	End of support 20 May 2026
Elastic Beanstalk AL2 platform branches	Retired 30 June 2026. Migrate to AL2023

ON THE EXAM

These differ from the closed features: there is no existing-customer carve-out. If older material recommends one, that recommendation is simply dead.

Renames in flight

OLDER NAME	CURRENT NAME
RDS Performance Insights	CloudWatch Database Insights. Console redirects; API persists
Aurora Serverless v2	Aurora serverless, renamed April 2026
Route 53 Application Recovery Controller	Amazon Application Recovery Controller
Security Hub	Security Hub CSPM. "Security Hub" is now the broader product
AWS Security Agent	Becoming Continuum pen testing and Continuum code scanning
AWS Fault Injection Simulator	AWS Fault Injection Service

ON THE EXAM

Answer with the exam guide's name and recognise the current one in the console. The guide still says "Aurora Serverless v2" and "AWS Security Agent".

Numbers that changed

LIMIT	OLD VALUE STILL PUBLISHED
gp3: 64 TiB, 80,000 IOPS, 2,000 MiB/s	16 TiB, 16,000 IOPS, 1,000 MiB/s
Logs Insights: 100 concurrent, 100,000 results	30 concurrent, 10,000 results
KMS rotation: 90 to 2,560 days, plus on-demand	Fixed annual, not configurable
VPN tunnels: 5 Gbps each	1.25 Gbps each
Aurora serverless: 256 ACUs, scales to zero	128 ACUs, minimum 0.5
Public IPv4: charged always, since Feb 2024	Free while attached

ON THE EXAM

Each of these changes the correct answer to a real question. gp3 reaching 80,000 IOPS removes the reason to choose io2 in many designs.

Facts that were true, and are now wrong

WHAT OLDER MATERIAL SAYS	WHAT IS TRUE NOW
ECS blue/green requires CodeDeploy	Native since July 2025. AWS recommends native for new work
ACM public certificates cannot be exported	Exportable since June 2025, chosen at request time
Terraform state locking needs a DynamoDB table	Deprecated. Use S3 native locking, use_lockfile
Logs Insights QL cannot do JOINs	JOIN and sub-query arrived April 2026
Instrument tracing with the X-Ray SDK	SDKs in maintenance mode. Use ADOT. The service is fine
Launch configurations are an option	Cannot be created at all in accounts made after 1 Oct 2024

ON THE EXAM

These are the dangerous ones. A stale limit makes you cautious; a stale fact makes you confidently choose a wrong answer.

The new services, in one place

- **AWS DevOps Agent**, GA 31 March 2026. Investigates incidents and produces a **mitigation plan for human approval**. It does not execute changes autonomously.
- **AWS Security Agent**, GA 31 March 2026. Agentic penetration testing, STRIDE threat modelling, repository and pull request scanning.
- **Kiro**, GA November 2025. Spec-driven agentic IDE. For operations it **authors automation rather than running it**. The Kiro autonomous agent is still preview.
- **Amazon S3 Files**, GA 7 April 2026. Mounts an S3 bucket as NFS v4.2, with the S3 API still working against the same data.

> ON THE EXAM
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> The DevOps Agent boundary is the exam-relevant detail: it investigates and proposes, and a human approves. Do not pick it as an answer that acts alone.

Amazon Q Developer and Kiro: get the nuance right

- **Amazon Q Developer is retiring.** New sign-ups blocked 15 May 2026; IDE plugins and paid subscriptions end 30 April 2027.
- **Kiro is the successor** for the agentic IDE, and joined the exam guide's in-scope list in version 1.1.
- **Q Developer inside the AWS console and other first-party experiences is NOT affected.** Only the standalone product is retiring.
- Q Developer was also **removed from the out-of-scope list** in v1.1, so it is no longer explicitly excluded from the exam.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Two things share a name and have opposite futures. Saying "Amazon Q Developer is going away" without qualification is wrong.

New capabilities that changed the standard answer

CAPABILITY	WHAT IT REPLACED
CloudFront VPC origins	A public ALB guarded by a secret custom header
ECS native blue/green	Wiring in CodeDeploy for every deployment
Drift-aware change sets	Detecting drift, then correcting it by hand
AutoScalingInstanceRefresh policy	Rigid rolling updates, or drift from refreshing outside the stack
Route 53 Global Resolver	Inbound endpoints plus per-site forwarding configuration
Resource control policies	Reviewing every bucket policy in every member account
Declarative policies	SCPs enumerating API actions, which new APIs bypass
Logically air-gapped vaults	Copying isolated backups somewhere usable before restoring

ON THE EXAM

Each of these makes an older, more laborious pattern the wrong answer. Recognising the older pattern in a distractor is worth as much as knowing the new one.

When the guide and reality disagree

- **Answer with the exam guide's terminology.** If it says Aurora Serverless v2, that is the name in the answer options.
- **Answer with current behaviour for limits.** Exams are updated for capability changes more readily than for naming.
- **Never choose a closed feature for new work.** Incident Manager and CloudTrail Lake are the ones most likely to appear as plausible distractors.
- **If two options differ only by name**, and one is the guide's name, take the guide's name.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> You are unlikely to be penalised for knowing something is newer than the question assumes. You can be penalised for not recognising the name in the options.

The patterns worth more than the facts

- **Measure before enforcing** appeared five times: Hooks warn mode, Allowed AMIs audit mode, predictive scaling forecast-only, DNS Firewall alert, WAF count.
- **Preventive, detective, corrective**: a Hook blocks it, Config finds it, Automation fixes it. Control Tower presents all three as one vocabulary.
- **An experienced colleague's advice has aged** appeared repeatedly, because AWS closes and replaces things faster than runbooks are rewritten.
- **Over-engineering is a wrong answer**, not a safe one. Meeting an agreed target beats exceeding it expensively.

> ON THE EXAM
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> AWS designs these patterns deliberately across services. Recognising the pattern often gets you to the answer faster than recalling the service.

> A question describes a team needing a queryable, immutable audit store for CloudTrail events across an organisation, and lists CloudTrail Lake among the options. The team is building this in 2026 and has never used CloudTrail Lake.
>
> The other options include an organisation trail delivering to S3 with Athena for queries.

How should you approach this?

A Choose the organisation trail with Athena, because CloudTrail Lake closed to new customers on 31 May 2026

B Choose CloudTrail Lake, because it is purpose-built and appears in the exam guide

C Choose CloudTrail Lake, because closures do not affect exam answers

D Assume CloudTrail is also closed and choose neither

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should you approach this?

A Organisation trail plus Athena

A team that has never used CloudTrail Lake cannot onboard after 31 May 2026. The alternative genuinely meets the requirement.

B CloudTrail Lake

Purpose-built and unavailable to this team. The scenario says they have never used it, which is the clause that closes the door.

C Closures do not matter

They do. A question describing new work in 2026 has a correct answer the team can actually implement.

D Assume CloudTrail is closed

Overcorrecting. CloudTrail itself is fully supported; only Lake closed. Precision about scope matters in both directions.

THE SIGNAL

Option D is the mirror-image error: knowing about a closure and applying it too broadly. Lake closed; CloudTrail did not.

> A question asks how to give a database team the ability to see database load broken down by wait event and SQL statement. The answer options include both 'RDS Performance Insights' and 'CloudWatch Database Insights'.
>
> You know Performance Insights reached end of life and the console now redirects.

Which do you choose?

A Whichever appears without the other; if both appear, the one matching the capability described

B Always CloudWatch Database Insights, because Performance Insights no longer exists

C Always RDS Performance Insights, because the exam guide predates the change

D Neither, because the capability was removed

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which do you choose?

A Match the capability described

Both names describe the same capability. Read what the question actually asks for, and pick the option describing it, rather than deciding on the name alone.

B Always Database Insights

Reasonable, and it fails if the question was written earlier and only offers the old name. The capability is what is being tested.

C Always Performance Insights

The mirror error. If the question offers only the new name, insisting on the old one leaves you with no answer.

D The capability was removed

It was renamed and extended, not removed. Advanced mode added lock diagnostics and execution plans that Performance Insights never had.

THE SIGNAL

Renames are the one case where a rigid rule fails. Learn the capability, recognise both names, and let the question's wording decide.

> A question describes needing 30,000 IOPS and asks which EBS volume type to choose. It offers gp3 and io1 among the options. There is no requirement for sub-millisecond latency or five-nines durability.
>
> You recall older material stating gp3 caps at 16,000 IOPS.

What should you choose?

A gp3, because it now supports up to 80,000 IOPS and no requirement points at io1

B io1, because gp3 cannot exceed 16,000 IOPS

C io2 Block Express, as the safest high-performance choice

D gp2 with a very large volume

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should you choose?

A gp3

Since September 2025 gp3 reaches 80,000 IOPS, and nothing in the requirement points at provisioned IOPS volumes. It is also substantially cheaper.

B io1

Based on a limit that changed in September 2025. It would work, at higher cost, for a reason that is no longer true.

C io2 Block Express

Over-engineering, which this course has repeatedly shown is a wrong answer rather than a safe one. No stated requirement justifies it.

D gp2 with a large volume

Would need over 10 TiB to reach 30,000 IOPS, and gp2 caps at 16,000 anyway. Expensive and insufficient.

THE SIGNAL

Unlike a rename, a raised limit is unambiguous. Answer with current capability, and remember that gp3's ceiling moved.

> A colleague reviewing your architecture says: "Amazon Q Developer is being retired, so remove any dependency on it. Also, our runbook says to use Systems Manager Incident Manager for on-call escalation, which is fine because we already have it configured."
>
> Both statements need checking.

Which assessment is correct?

A. The first is overstated: only standalone Q Developer is retiring, not Q Developer in the console. The second is correct: existing Incident Manager customers keep it

B. Both statements are correct as given

C. Both statements are wrong

D. The first is correct and the second is wrong, because Incident Manager was removed entirely

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

Which assessment is correct?

A First overstated, second correct

Q Developer in the console is unaffected, so the blanket claim is wrong. Incident Manager closed to NEW customers only, so an existing configuration continues.

B Both correct

The Q Developer claim is too broad. Console and first-party Q Developer experiences continue unchanged.

C Both wrong

Overcorrecting. The Incident Manager statement is accurate: closed to new customers is not the same as withdrawn.

D Incident Manager removed entirely

It closed to new customers on 7 November 2025. Existing customers keep it, which is precisely what the colleague described.

THE SIGNAL

Both halves test precision about scope. Retiring is not the same as removed, and closed to new customers is not the same as gone.

The five things to carry forward

- **65 questions, 130 minutes, 150 dollars, no labs.** Widely misreported, and worth being certain about.
- **Containers, CDK, Terraform and Git are new scope.** C02-era material has no equivalent content.
- **Four features are closed to new customers** and still in the guide. Never propose them for new work.
- **Answer with the guide's name and current behaviour** for limits. Recognise both names for renamed services.
- **Over-engineering is a wrong answer**, and "measure before enforcing" is a design instinct AWS rewards.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Next: confusion pairs - the services that look like each other, and the single question that separates each pair.